Mid-Term Evaluation of the Girls' Basic Education Support Programme (GEP-2019-02)

Al-Rayhan Development Foundation

Prepared by Corvane Evaluation Partners for the Thornvale Education Trust — December 2020

> Synthetic document for demonstration and testing. All names, figures and organisations in it are fictional.

Item	Detail
Project code	GEP-2019-02
Donor	Thornvale Education Trust
Grant amount	USD 900,000
Project period	1 September 2019 – 31 August 2022 (36 months)
Location	30 public basic schools, Sahl Al-Qamar governorate
Fieldwork	5 October – 20 November 2020
Evaluation team	Hannah Brightwell and Yasmin Darwish (pseudonyms)

About this report

This mid-term evaluation was commissioned under Clause 9 of the grant agreement between the Thornvale Education Trust and the Al-Rayhan Development Foundation. It assesses progress against the project's targets at roughly the halfway point, documents how the project adapted when schools closed during the COVID-19 pandemic, and makes recommendations for the remaining twenty months.

The evaluation was independent. Foundation staff helped arrange field visits and shared monitoring data, but did not take part in interviews or in drafting the findings. The Foundation's management response is filed separately.

Executive summary

Despite six months of school closures, the project is broadly on track, and our overall rating is **satisfactory**.

The headline result is encouraging. Girls' enrolment in the 30 target schools rose from 61% at baseline in September 2019 to 68% in October 2020. The end-of-project target of 75% remains achievable if the second half of the project runs without major disruption.

Progress on outputs is uneven:

- **School kits.** 3,150 girls had received a full kit (bag, stationery and uniform) out of the 3,600 planned. This component is ahead of schedule.
- **Teacher training.** 96 of the planned 150 teachers have completed the inclusive-teaching course. Face-to-face sessions stopped in March and resumed only in October.
- **Latrine blocks.** 18 of 30 girl-friendly latrine blocks are finished. Construction slowed while contractors could not travel between districts.
- **Remote learning.** When schools closed, the Foundation and the local education directorate broadcast daily lessons on community radio. We estimate that about 2,400 girls followed them regularly, based on a call-back survey of enrolled families.

By 31 October 2020 the project had spent USD 372,000, or 41% of the grant, with 39% of the project period elapsed. Overall spending is therefore roughly on schedule. That average hides a gap between components: school kits are well ahead, while training and community work are behind because those activities were paused.

Our main recommendations are to catch up on teacher training during the 2021 summer break, to finish the remaining latrine blocks before winter, and to keep radio lessons as a permanent complement to classroom teaching.

Background

The Foundation has worked on girls' education in Sahl Al-Qamar since 2016, building on its 2015 study of enrolment in the governorate. That study found that distance to school, early marriage, the cost of supplies and the lack of separate latrines for girls were the main reasons girls left school.

GEP-2019-02 scales the earlier pilot up to 30 schools and has four components:

1. School kits for girls from the poorest households.
2. Training for teachers and head teachers in inclusive, gender-responsive teaching.
3. Construction of girl-friendly latrine blocks with handwashing points.
4. Community mobilisation through mothers' councils and awareness sessions with religious and community leaders.

Methodology

The evaluation used mixed methods:

- a review of enrolment and attendance records in all 30 schools, cross-checked against head-count visits in 10 schools
- a structured survey of 420 girls in grades 4 to 9 and 260 parents
- 12 focus group discussions, six with girls and six with mothers
- 18 key informant interviews with head teachers, directorate staff, contractors and Foundation staff

Limitations

Fieldwork took place under movement restrictions, so two of the planned school visits were replaced with telephone interviews. Enrolment figures for October 2020 may slightly overstate attendance, because some families registered daughters without being sure they would attend in person. We therefore treat the 68% figure as an upper estimate of real participation.

Findings: effectiveness

The table compares each key indicator with its baseline and its end-of-project target.

Indicator	Baseline (Sep 2019)	Target (Aug 2022)	Mid-term (Oct 2020)
Girls' enrolment rate, target schools	61%	75%	68%
Girls who received a school kit	0	3,600	3,150
Teachers trained in inclusive teaching	0	150	96
Girl-friendly latrine blocks completed	0	30	18
Schools with an active mothers' council	4	30	21
Girls' attendance before closures (share of school days)	78%	90%	84%

Girls and mothers in every focus group named the school kits as the most visible benefit. Several mothers said the uniform mattered as much as the stationery, because it removed a source of embarrassment for poorer girls.

Head teachers in schools with new latrine blocks reported fewer absences among older girls. This is consistent with the 2015 finding that missing facilities kept girls at home after puberty.

The mothers' councils are the component with the most potential for lasting change. In 21 schools they now meet at least once a month and have followed up directly with families of girls at risk of leaving school.

Findings: adaptation, efficiency and sustainability

Schools in the governorate were closed from 15 March to 27 September 2020. Within three weeks the project had redirected part of its community budget to radio lessons and printed learning packs. Girls without access to a radio were given packs through the mothers' councils.

Component	Budget (USD)	Spent by 31 Oct 2020	Share spent
School kits	252,000	148,000	59%
Teacher training	180,000	61,000	34%
Latrine blocks	270,000	118,000	44%
Community mobilisation	63,000	19,000	30%
Management, M&E and indirect costs	135,000	26,000	19%
Total	**900,000**	**372,000**	**41%**

Unit costs are reasonable. A full school kit costs about USD 47, which is in line with local market prices.

On sustainability, the latrine blocks have been handed over to school maintenance committees. The mothers' councils are unlikely to keep meeting without some light support after the project ends.

Conclusions

GEP-2019-02 is relevant, well managed and on track for most of its targets. Its most important achievement so far is the seven-point rise in girls' enrolment in target schools. The most serious risk is the teacher-training backlog: if it is not cleared in 2021, the quality gains expected in the final year will not materialise.

Recommendations

1. **Clear the training backlog.** Train the remaining 54 teachers in intensive sessions during the 2021 summer break, and offer a short refresher to those trained before the closures.
2. **Finish construction before winter.** Complete the remaining 12 latrine blocks by November 2021, starting with the schools that have the largest enrolment of girls in grades 7 to 9.
3. **Keep the radio lessons.** Continue weekly radio lessons as a complement to classroom teaching, and record them so they can be reused in future closures.
4. **Track girls at risk.** Introduce a simple early-warning list in each school, maintained with the mothers' councils, for girls absent more than five days a month.
5. **Plan the exit early.** Agree with the education directorate by mid-2021 who will support the mothers' councils after August 2022.
6. **Prepare the final evaluation.** Use the same indicators and school sample in the final evaluation so the results can be compared directly with this report.

We do not recommend a no-cost extension at this stage. The project should be reviewed again in mid-2021, once the effect of the reopening on enrolment is clearer.